

# Publishing Your Changes

*How an edit travels from the workspace to your live website — and how to test it safely first.*

## The big picture

Making a change is only half the job — the change also has to be published before the public can see it. Here is the whole journey at a glance:



The key thing to remember: a change that only lives in the workspace is not live yet. It becomes live once it is saved (“pushed”) to GitHub, and the host (Render) automatically rebuilds and publishes the site.

## The three places involved

- **The workspace** — where you make the edit and preview how it looks.
- **GitHub** — the official storage that holds the real copy of the site. Nothing goes live until it arrives here.
- **Render** — the host that runs the live website and republishes automatically when GitHub receives a new change.

## A few words in plain language

- **Branch** — a separate copy you can change without affecting the live one. “main” is the real/live copy; “staging” is a safe practice copy.
- **Commit** — saving a snapshot of your changes with a short note describing them.
- **Push** — sending your saved changes up to GitHub. This starts the path to going live.
- **Merge** — copying finished, tested changes from one branch (staging) into another (main).

## How to publish (no command line needed)

In the workspace:

- 1 **Open the version-control panel** (the branching icon in the left tool strip).
- 2 **Review the changed files** so you know exactly what you are about to publish.

- 3 **Write a short message** describing the change, e.g. “Updated hero headline and button color.”
- 4 **Click Commit, then Push.** Your change is now on its way to the live site.

You can also simply ask the assistant to “commit and push these changes” — just always review what it is about to publish first.

## | Which branch am I on, and where do I find it?

There are exactly two branches, and they already exist — you do not create them:

- **main** — the real, live copy. What's here is (or is about to be) on the public website.
- **staging** — the safe practice copy. Changes here are NOT public until you copy them into main.

To see or change which branch you're on, in the workspace:

- 1 **Open the version-control panel** (the branching icon in the left tool strip).
- 2 **Read the current branch name at the top of that panel** — this tells you whether you're on main or staging right now. Check it before you start.
- 3 **Click that branch name and choose staging (or main)** to switch. The workspace and preview reload to show that branch's version.

**Where you actually see each version:**

- **The preview pane** always shows the branch you currently have checked out — so when staging is selected, the preview IS your staging test view.
- **A separate staging website** (a private URL you can open in any browser, even on your phone) only exists if your developer set one up on Render. Ask them for the address and write it down:  
Staging site: \_\_\_\_\_. Live site: <https://lyslessonplanning.com>

## | Workflow A — quick, low-risk changes

Use this only for small edits you are confident about (a typo, a color, swapping an image). You work directly on the live copy (“main”):

- 1 Make your change on the main branch.
- 2 Preview it and confirm it looks right.
- 3 Commit with a clear message and push to GitHub.
- 4 Render republishes in a few minutes — check the live site.

Because “main” is the live copy, a mistake here can appear publicly before you catch it. For anything bigger than a trivial tweak, use Workflow B.

## Workflow B — test on staging first (recommended)

This lets you rehearse changes safely, then publish once you are happy:

- 1 **Switch to the staging branch** (see “Which branch am I on” above). Confirm the branch name at the top of the panel now reads staging.
- 2 **Make your change and preview it** in the preview pane — it's showing staging because that's the branch you're on.
- 3 **Commit and push** (this pushes to the staging branch). If a staging website was set up on Render, open its address to see it live on a private URL, with no risk to the public site.
- 4 **Test it thoroughly.** Check the affected pages on both phone and computer, and make sure nothing else broke.
- 5 **When satisfied, copy staging into main via a Pull Request on GitHub:** go to [github.com/lys-admin-user/lys-classroom-app](https://github.com/lys-admin-user/lys-classroom-app), click Pull requests, set it to merge staging into main, review, then Merge.
- 6 **Render publishes it to the live site automatically** (<https://lyslessonplanning.com>), usually within a few minutes.

*In short: practice on staging -> prove it works -> promote to main -> it goes live.*

## Before every publish — quick checklist

- The change is a visual / wording change (not data, logins, payments, permissions, or settings). If it touches those, stop and ask your developer.
- You previewed it and it looks right.
- Your commit message clearly says what changed.
- For anything beyond a tiny tweak, you did it on staging and tested before merging to main.

**If something looks wrong after publishing, don't worry — nothing is permanent. You can roll back to an earlier checkpoint in the workspace, and every past version is saved in GitHub, so your developer can restore the last good version quickly. When in doubt, pause and send them a short note of what changed.**